Georgia Homelessness: Shelter Capacity Gaps by Continuum of Care

Alfredo Alea · Data / AI Engineer · Public-data analysis, 2026 · Python (pandas, matplotlib) · reproducible pipeline with an automated verification log

BUSINESS QUESTION

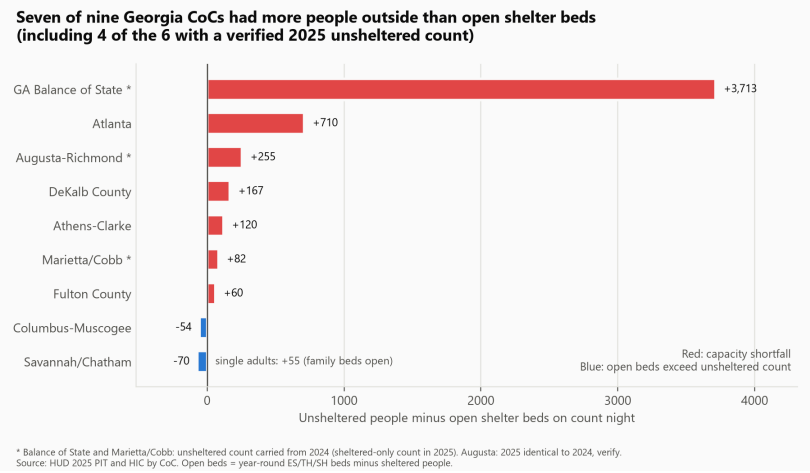
HUD's 2025 figures show 12,284 people experiencing homelessness in Georgia, 54% of them unsheltered. Is each Continuum of Care (CoC) short of shelter beds, or does it have beds people aren't using? Funders need to know which, because the two problems need different investments.

DATA AND METHOD

- **Sources:** HUD Point-in-Time counts by CoC (2015–2025) and the 2025 Housing Inventory Count, all 9 Georgia CoCs, from the HUD 2025 AHAR data page.
- **Pipeline:** one script ingests the HUD workbooks, validates them (carried-forward counts, COVID-year zeros, duplicate rows, join completeness), computes the metrics and writes charts, CSVs and `verification_log.txt`. To re-run: `python -I scripts/ga_capacity_gap_analysis.py .`
- **Metrics:** open beds = year-round emergency, transitional and safe-haven beds minus people sheltered on count night. Gap = unsheltered people minus open beds. Repeated for single adults.

KEY FINDINGS

- **7 of 9 CoCs** had more people outside than open beds, including **4 of the 6** with a verified 2025 unsheltered count. Atlanta: **+710**.
- Balance of State shows the largest gap (**+3,713**), but that figure uses its 2024 unsheltered count, which HUD carried into 2025. Its 2024 count of 4,407 was the highest among years with a new count (2021 excluded as a COVID-era sheltered-only waiver), though its counts swing widely (1,873–4,407).
- Shelters were only **65–84% full**. Columbus had more empty beds than people outside. In Savannah, about half the open beds were for families or youth, leaving single adults **55 beds short**.



RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Add shelter capacity in Atlanta and Balance of State.
2. Columbus: check restricted beds (up to 43 of 357 are DV, veteran or youth beds) before funding outreach and lower-barrier entry instead of beds.
3. Savannah: convert family units to adult beds.
4. Augusta: confirm the 2025 count, which is identical to 2024.

VERIFICATION AND LIMITS

- HUD reuses the prior unsheltered count in sheltered-only years. I found 11 such rows and excluded them from trends. The single-adult check overturned the first conclusion for Savannah.
- The data is a single January night. There are no per-capita rates, and Balance of State's beds and people may be counties apart.
- Public aggregate data only. This mirrors the type of analysis I led in a previous public-sector data role.